

Asking Simple Questions

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Simple questions. Deep insights.

TL;DR

The Executive Summary

A vast amount of information hides in plain sight. Behind the veneer of well-functioning teams are areas that may quietly warrant attention. While the first instinct may be to look for complicated solutions, a closer examination reveals that simple questions can be enough to uncover deeper insights into how an organization is functioning.

Unlocking Deep Insights

A surprisingly vast amount of information stays hidden under the veneer of well-functioning teams. As software gets built day after day, less visible aspects of work take shape: how communication flows among engineers, whether they feel a sense of purpose behind what they build, whether they can focus deeply on their work, how they feel about where their career is headed, and whether they have sufficient bandwidth for daily tasks provide vital signals about how the organization is functioning. Asking engineers simple questions about these aspects of their work can help bring hidden signals to surface. As an example, consider the question “Is there effective communication at work?”

Communication plays a vital role in how software gets built. Conway’s Law suggests that the architecture of the system tends to reflect the communication structures of the organization that builds it. Understanding how engineers communicate can provide insights into how the architecture of the system emerges and help identify where communication is effective and where friction exists.

Looking at the patterns of communication among engineers of the organization provides signals on which areas may need attention. For example, it is worth examining whether communication flows primarily vertically through the chain of command or laterally among engineers. These patterns reveal how information moves through the organization.

When information primarily flows through the chain of command, it can introduce delays into the development process. Each handoff requires context to be transferred from one person to another, creating opportunities for information to be lost, diluted, or misunderstood along the way. A tangible example is when teams effectively “throw tickets over a wall,” with work handed from one group to another and progress depending on successive managerial or organizational handoffs.

In contrast, communication can flow laterally among engineers without always going through the chain of command. This reduces the number of handoffs and allows context to reach the people doing the work directly. In turn, this can reduce coordination overhead and speed up development, while allowing architectural decisions to emerge from direct communication among the engineers involved.

The answer to the question posed in the opening paragraph – “Is there effective communication at work?” – can reveal how engineers perceive the way information flows through the organization, including whether communication happens primarily through the chain of command or directly among engineers. While there are circumstances where the information needs to flow through the chain, making it the predominant form of communication can slow down development by introducing handoffs. Posing this one simple question provides insight into how the engineers perceive information flows in the organization.

Looking at the answer to this question provides insight into how information flows in the organization and reveals areas where communication patterns may be creating friction. Similarly, asking simple questions about the other aspects outlined in the opening paragraph can reveal areas of the organization that may warrant closer attention. That is the power of simple questions: deep insights.